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THE AYMERS.

CHAPTER XIV.

[Conclusion of the Chapter.]

[illegible]

(To be Continued.)

FOREIGN CORRESPONDENCE.

Number LXXV.

TAMSUI, FORMOSA, December 1st, 1873.

After more than two weeks' stay among the Sek-whan at Posia, we finally got ready to move out toward the coast. Our stay had impressed me at least with the Christian kindness and hospitality of this rude people. Without the crafty and niggardly spirit of the Chinese, we could hardly prevail upon them to take pay for what we bought of them, poor as they are.

As we left them, one peng-an and shake of the hand was not sufficient; but old men and women would run on before us, and take a new turn at it blessing us and asking us to remember them when we got back to our own Christian lands, and to tell the Christians there that they were trying to do right. Quite a party of men and women accompanied us a couple of miles, wading the river, to bid us a last farewell. It is a two days' march through the territory of the Che-whan before the cultivated country of the Chinese is reached, and the Sek-whan only pass through in large bands, that they may be safe from attack. Our party numbered about seventy, most of them armed with firelocks.

All of the first day we followed down the river, now quite a stream, with all the branches from the valley of Posia united; so that we found it difficult to ford, though we had to do so several times during the day. About noon we heard a deer bleating near the path, and several men dashed off after it, thinking it was caught in a snare, such as the Sek-whan often use for the purpose; but it happened that the deer—one of a small species—had been caught in the claws of a large eagle that was not able to fly off with it. The eagle, on seeing the men, flew away, and the deer, dazed at first, ran to the men who, not expecting anything of the kind, were not prepared to shoot, and after striking at it with a knife, lost it. When they returned and told the story, they gave as a reason for not capturing it, that their Heavenly Father had not given it to them.

Just before stopping for the night, we passed through a fine valley, where several hundred Sek-whan once settled, the walls of the houses, and the ditches and terraces for irrigation still existing, but overgrown with bushes and wild grass. After losing a hundred men from repeated attacks of the Che-whan, they had to give the settlement up and retreat to a safer place. Crossing the river at this place for the last time, we came to a number of grass covered huts under a wooded bank, where such parties as ours were accustomed to pass the night, and there were soon a dozen camp fires burning, while several of the party took their guns and went off to hunt, and others turned the little brook, that ran near, out of its course, and got a good supply of shrimps and small fish. After supper, all gathered together for worship, and then several hymns were sung to their own wild music, and the camp gradually settled down to sleep.

The next morning we crossed a steep mountain and down into the valley of a small stream, that had cut a channel a hundred feet deep in some places, through drift, leaving perpendicular walls on either side. In some places this channel was but five or six feet in width, so that we walked in single file. The drift was often very coarse, and there were many trunks of trees that had partially or entirely turned to coal. We could tell when we had reached nearly to the boundary of Chinese settlement, by seeing the hills bare of trees and covered with coarse grass. Several of these hills had little watch houses built upon them, from which to warn the people of the approach of the Che-whan, and we could see men upon these watching us, and could hear them call to others beyond to let them know of our coming. These little stations are often the scenes of bloody encounters between the Chinese and savages, and we were pointed to one where the Che-whan had stolen up at night, with dry grass, and burned the Chinese to death.

We could now begin to see the Chinese at work, cutting timber and grass on the hills, and soon after we came out into the great plain east of the large walled city of Chungwha. That night we stopped with a very hospitable Chinaman, though an opium smoker, and owner of a large estate, much of it planted to sugar cane, a part of which was already being ground, and made up into a rather dark grade of sugar. We understood that the little watch towers we had seen were supported by this man personally, as his estate borders upon the savage territory. He treated us to a genuine Chinese supper of a dozen or more little bowls of fish, flesh and fowl, with vegetables, cooked in different ways. He sat down with us, and was very polite, putting bits of whatever he considered especially nice upon our plates, using his chop sticks as a means of conveyance.

Three hours' walk the next morning brought us to Toasia, a town of the Sek-whan, and, as near as we could find out, the original home of the tribe. The lands about it are very rich, and were covered with a very heavy crop of rice that was just being harvested; but the most of the fields have fallen into the hands of the Chinese, and those still held by the Sek-whan are covered with debt.

The Tungson, the head man of the Sek-whan, who has bought a small mandarinship of the Chinese, lives in this place, and he immediately set about making a great feast in honor of our arrival, killing a cow, a couple of hogs, fowls, etc. Three or four great kettles were set up near the little chapel, and filled and set to boiling, and there was an immense amount of preparation. The table was spread in the chapel, and there were some forty or fifty to dinner, and enough for twice as many. There were no toasts, but the Tungson told some of the grievances of the Sek-whan, from their grasping neighbors, the Chinese, with the hope, perhaps, that Mr. Bullock, being connected with the English consulate, could help them out.

We parted company at this place, Mr. Bullock returning to Taiwaufu, by way of Chungwha, while Mr. Campbell and I went on north twelve or fifteen miles, to the Sek-whan settlement of Laisia. This is a very pretty valley among the hills, containing two villages and, perhaps, eight hundred people,—all Christians, or, at least, all worshipers, as there is not an idol or tablet in either of the villages. They received their first ideas of Christianity from the old hunter Kisanhia, who had been treated at the missionary hospital at Taiwaufu, and they threw away their idols and received Christianity almost in one day. They received us very kindly, and, as in Posia, they had a little house built for the missionaries when they should visit them, and in this we proceeded to make ourselves comfortable.

I was very much amused with the salutation we received every day as we came from dinner at the house of the helper near by. There were generally half a dozen old women who cried out: "Chiah-pah-la?"—have you eaten until you are full?—this seeming to be the nearest complete happiness that this poor people can think of attaining on this earth.

They were expecting to begin their harvest the next week, and were busy preparing for it by distilling a weak spirit from rice. The missionaries are not Americans, and have only counseled them to moderation, instead of enjoining entire abstinence. There were large hunting parties out, also, that brought in three wild hogs, one of them very large and with enormous tusks. They are black, and probably only the ordinary Chinese breed run wild, though there is a curious and very small species found upon the island.

Mr. Campbell and I, while at Laisia, made a trip to a town inhabited by Hakkas, called Twalam, some ten miles south east, where we expected to see more Che-whan, as it is a point where they frequently come to trade. This was the first place where I had seen Hakkas, though the northern part of the island has almost as many of them as of other Chinese. They are supposed to come from the province of Canton, though they do not speak Cantonese. They do not bandage the feet of their women, generally live apart from the other Chinese, and are called Ke-lang, or strangers, by them. They are a hardy, industrious race, and seem to be braver than the ordinary Chinese, as they generally occupy the frontier next the savages. We saw no savages but two or three women, who, by similarity of tattooing, would seem to be closely allied to those we saw east of Posia. Their villages are very near those of the Chinese here, as they pointed out brown patches on the mountain sides a few miles back, where their settlements were.

The country about Twalam was much of it high table land, without water for irrigation, and hence uncultivated and grown up to a tall feather grass. These table lands were likely, at no very distant time, part of the valleys, but the streams have cut down to another level and left them high and dry. The streams cut through badly tilted strata of coarse sandstone, in which I found quite a number of fossils.

The Sek-whan had bought, by general subscription, four dollars' worth of fish poison, a root raised by the Chinese, and one morning twenty-five or thirty men and women, the men all with fire locks, for we were going into the country of the Che-whan, set out up the little stream upon which the villages are built. We must have gone five or six miles over the worst road possible, fording the stream every few minutes, and then climbing steep banks through the thorns, until we had finally reached a spot deemed favorable, where there was a deep pool. Men and women now sat down upon the rocks, and began beating the roots they had brought for poisoning the fish. This mess was then put into the upper end of the pool, gradually going down with the current, and turning the water to a milky whiteness. While waiting for this to have its effect upon the fish, the people gathered in little groups to take their dinner, a blessing being reverently asked in each group over the little basket of rice and pickled cabbage that formed their simple fare. They brought me of the best they had, and one of them whittled out a stick to serve me for a spoon. By the time dinner was over, the fish began to rise to the top of the water, and to go swimming about on their sides, coming out to the banks as if in search of purer water. The Whans now began spearing them, and taking them in nets, following the poison down stream; but, though two or three quite large fish were caught, the affair turned out rather a failure for some reason that I could not find out.

Mr. Campbell now turned back toward the south end of the island, while I hired three young men of the Sek-whan to carry my baggage and collections, and with my boy Onga to act as interpreter, I started for Tamsui. From Laisia we traveled some fifteen or twenty miles over hills and rolling lands, mostly of reddish clay. They were thinly inhabited, from lack of water; but they had been cleared of timber generally, and were now covered with coarse, high grass. Wherever this was burned off, it showed stumps and trunks of huge camphor trees. In one place I saw one standing of seven or eight feet in diameter, while in places a little sheltered from the fires there was plenty of wild tea growing, I noticing in one place a tree in full bloom, thirty feet in height and a foot or more in diameter. From these hills we struck out toward the sea, coming out at the port of the city of Oulan, where there were quite a number of junks lying, and a large number of emigrants from the main land were just landing and starting off to find employment, each with his bag or basket of clothing and a huge Chinese umbrella.

From this port we again went inland, and left the rice fields, crossing high plateaus, uncultivated, with little valleys intersecting them, that were carefully irrigated, and we stopped for the night in the little town of Tung Kiang, where I passed the night in a dirty little inn filled with fleas and other creeping things.

The second day was mostly spent in traveling over high plains, with the wind blowing strong in our faces, as the north east trade wind, or monsoon, had set in. We passed several villages and the walled city of Tekcham, a large part of the population being Hakkas. The second night I stopped at a little town in the hills, and the next day made our way to Sinchin upon the river, and taking a small boat, we arrived here in the evening.

The northern part of Formosa does not seem so fertile as the southern and middle portion, and is much more too high for irrigation; but the soil of these high plains and hills seems well fitted for tea, and the cultivation of this plant seems capable of almost any amount of extension here. If these high lands were cultivated with better implements than the little Chinese plow, drawn by one cow, that only cuts a furrow two or three inches in depth, they might raise other crops during the rainy season; but the Chinaman makes irrigation do much of his work for him, letting on the water to soften the soil before he plows, and then irrigating again to soften the clods made by plowing the ground when wet, and when he can not irrigate, his cultivation is necessarily poor.

J. B. STEERE.

Four Scenes in the High Sierras.

A TRIP TO YO-SEMITE.

BY J. G. LEMMON,

[illegible]

No. 6.—From Yo-Semite to the Silver Mines.

LEAVING YO-SEMITE.

[illegible]

SILVER MOUNTAIN.

[illegible]

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